

STYLISTIC EVOLUTION IN THE HISTORY OF WEB DESIGN

INDEX:

1. Introduction	3
2. Flat design vs Scheumorphic design	5
3. Why do we talk about modern design	6
4. Ornament in digital world	8
5. The history of web design	10
5.1 What happens in the world of the web	10
5.2 The evolution and fall of Flash	11
5.3 Apple, Microsoft and Google in the evolution of the history of web design	11
5.4 The Modern UI is spelled out by Microsoft as simple, clean and modern	11
5.5 The Material Design revolution	11
5.6 From the history of web design to the future	12
6. Authentic design	13
7. What makes design more “authentic”?	13
8. Modernism 2.0	14
9. Conclusions	15
10. Bibliography	15

1. Introduction

There is a profound stylistic continuity between modern architecture and digital design.

Why does a human being show that he loves Internet? Deliberately inappropriate verbs such as “love” are used to predict a resemblance to Adolf Loos: *“Man loves all that is needed for his comfort, hates all that bothers him and wants to take him out. That's why he loves the house and hates art.”*

It is important to underline the conflicting relationship of **architecture** with its art as it **is somehow parallel to the use of the contemporary Internet**.

The central idea is that art itself is an expression of the individual, who may or may not like his personality, but is still the daughter of his own expression, conceived by his own spirituality and given to the world. With this definition begins the detachment from architecture: the latter responds in the first place to different needs and cannot be considered a mere work of art. Its matrix will fail to serve the people who live there:

“Everyone has to like the house. Unlike the work of art, which does not need to please anyone. The work of art is a private matter of the artist. The house no. The work of art is brought into the world without there being a need for it. The house, on the other hand, satisfies a need”.

It is this need that must be met that, for Loos, life has nothing to do with art, or rather, aesthetic/artistic values should be overshadowed. For this reason, a designer cannot and must not be considered an artist precisely because his work, unlike a work of art, is brought into the world because it is necessary. *“The work of art is not responsible to anyone, the home to everyone. The work of art wants to tear men away from their comforts. The home is at the service of comfort. The work of art is revolutionary, the house is conservative. The work of art shows humanity new ways and thinks about the future. The house thinks about the present.”*

Likewise, people like computers and everything they contain, because they figuratively represent a home. House within house. The computer, beyond the purely hardware aspect, its operating system and its window interface, the applications that we need or do not need, at all technical and aesthetic scales, is officially an infrastructure place where users can:

- Customize at will, according to your tastes
- Reach the information you want and that you consider most appropriate
- Manage the activities that are carried out as you see fit
- Develop content if you want. Any kind of content
- Socialize and connect with other groups of people

Basically choosing what, who and how. In total autonomy and without moving from your station. In a certain sense, it is an elevation of home comfort and probably for this reason too it has been so successful. Becoming in effect a place, a cave from which man defends himself from the bad weather of the world in which he lives.

By maximizing the concept taken up by Heidegger, another effort is made towards the definition of living. Professor Anna Cicognani, from the Faculty of Architecture at the University of Sydney *“proposes, among other possible, five criteria to qualify 'spaces': 1. The possibility of interaction, with which she means 'the possibility of physical transformations in space'; 2. 'liveability' or 'employability' (the possibility of living in a space); 3. Ability to build communities (which you rightly emphasize, 'may exist beyond their geographical location'); 4. Time management opportunities and 5. Space.”*

Today Internet is proof that this space - this cyberspace - exists, works and has rules that are very similar to the sensitive space we live and inhabit.

If Loos has been mentioned it is because in the last period there is also a lot of talk about him in the blogosphere. Not so much of his buildings, but of the correlation between the modern style in architecture he initiated and the aesthetic drift that Internet sites and computer software have assimilated today, the so-called flat design.

Dmitry Fadeyev, web designer, was the first to certify this interest thanks to his article titled “authentic design” in Smashing Magazine. And he sparked a real interest in apparently so distant themes. The recently

advertised "flat" interface style is not just a trend, it is the manifestation of a desire for greater authenticity in design, the desire to curb visual excess and eliminate the false and superfluous.

2. Flat design vs Scheumorphic design

Flat design or **minimal design** does not include shadows, color shades and complicated artifices. The color is well contemplated but much more is aimed at tone-on-tone and in any case in soft colors that are not too bright or aggressive.

In creating new opportunities, technological advancement sometimes leads to areas of excess. In the 19th century, industrial production allowed the cost of ornaments to be brought down quickly and economically, thus leading to the creation of over-decorated goods. A similar thing has occurred in the last few years of computer and digital design, when visualization and styling technologies have enabled designers to create visually rich interfaces, which have led to stylistic excess in terms of decoration and excessive use of **scheumorphic design**.

In its desire for authenticity, the so-called modern movement in architecture has curbed the excessive ornamental use of the 19th century, trying to give an architectural response to the era of mass production.

Today, we are seeing the same desire for authenticity manifesting itself in the flat design trend, which rejects chipping and excessive decoration in favour of a design for the simpler, clean, and focused on content.

The **Scheumorphism** before Windows 8 was used a lot by Microsoft but remember that Apple is also famous for the use of sound schemes such as emptying the trash, the sound of the screenshot etc.

In short, scheumorphism means remembering, through sounds, images and icons, something that is more similar to reality.



An example of scheumorfism and flat design.

3. Why do we talk about modern design

In 1908, Adolf Loos, an influential Austrian designer, wrote an essay with the provocative title “Ornament and crime”.

The modern ornamentist, he argued, was either a *“Cultural laggard or a pathological case. He himself is forced to disown his work after three years. His productions di lui are unbearable to cultured persons now, and he will become so to others in a little while ”*. Even more boldly, Loos stated: *“The lower the standard of a people, the more lavish are its ornaments. To find beauty in form instead of making it depend on ornament is the goal towards which humanity is aspiring.”*

What triggered the attack on the so-called ornament? To understand the mentality of this pioneer of modern design, we must first get an idea of the state of design in the late 19th century.

The advent of the steam engine ushered in the era of industrial production. The art critic Frank Whitford wrote in fact: *“Steam-driven machines could stamp, cut and fashion almost any substance faster and more regularly than the human hand. Mechanized production meant lower prices and higher profits.”*

But while the production method varied, the architectural and design style of objects of more or less common use remained the same without evolving. Most of the products, from the construction world to that of furniture, fabrics and cutlery, were embellished with an abundant coat of ornament.

Historically, handcrafted decoration was very expensive to produce, which at the time symbolized a state of wealth and consequent luxury. With the advent of industrialization, the costs and times to imitate these refined ornaments could be cut down. Instead of pausing and pondering what kind of design would be best suited to mass production, manufacturers jumped at the chance to copy historicized styles at low cost. The result was the jumble of flamboyant, low-quality products that Adolf Loos, along with others later attributable to the modern movement (think Bauhaus), lashed out at.

In the book “The Decorative Art of Today”, Le Corbusier bluntly stated that garbage is abundantly decorated, and that, *“The luxury object is well-made, neat and clean, pure and healthy, and its bareness reveals the quality of its manufacture. It is to industry that we owe the reversal in this state of affairs: a cast-iron stove overflowing with decoration costs less than a plain one; amidst the surging leaf patterns flaws in the casting cannot be seen.”*

Montgomery Schuyler, an authoritative critic and journalist, also waged a battle against the ornate facades of the 19th century, saying: *“If you were to scrape down to the face of the main wall of the buildings of these streets, you would find that you had simply removed all the architecture, and that you had left the buildings as good as ever.”*

Again Louis Sullivan, designer known as “the father of skyscrapers”, moderately said *“It would be greatly for our aesthetic good, if we should refrain entirely from the use of ornament for a period of years, in order that our thought might concentrate acutely upon the production of buildings well-formed and comely in the nude.”*

During the 1920s, a new movement emerges in Germany known as Sachlichkeit, which can be translated as “practical”, “objective”.

This Neue Sachlichkeit movement carries out research in the field of design, asserting that **aesthetics must match utility**. German designer Hermann Muthesius explained how this idea of utility in aesthetics can produce something he called Maschinenstil, or “machine style”. We find examples of this in *“railway stations, exhibition halls, bridges, steamships, etc. Here we are faced with a severe and almost scientific Sachlichkeit, with abstinence from all outward decoration, and with shapes completely dictated by the purposes which they are meant to serve.”*

Other designers of the time, instead of attacking the ornament, focused on the elevation of the form / function concept. In 1934, an exhibition curated by modernist designer Philip Johnson was held at the New York Museum of Modern Art, entitled “Machine Art”. The exhibit was made up of various pieces of mechanical equipment, such as aircraft propellers and industrial insulators. The idea was to highlight the

beauty of form in objects that were purely functional. For the modern movement, decoration in furniture was not necessary. Beauty and elegance emerge from the design itself, not from a superficial decoration.

Much of the first half of the 20th century saw the tastes and ideas of the modernist movement prevail, and traditional styles and techniques were eventually superseded by these more recent approaches. In his book "Twentieth-Century Design" Jonathan Woodham observes that modern aesthetics have been characterized by *"clean, geometric forms, the use of modern materials such as chromium-plated steel and glass, and plain surfaces articulated by the abstract manipulation of light and shade. The use of color was often restrained, with an emphasis on white, off-white, gray, and black."* Modern design had thus abandoned the idea of beauty in ornamentation and found beauty in a harmonious fusion of form and function.

However, it would be wrong to think that only the modern movement in those years characterized their design aesthetics as "anti-ornamental". New styles came and went, such as the popular art nouveau or art deco movements. Some, like futurism, pushed for an aesthetic aimed at exaggerated technology, while others, like De Stijl, sought harmony in a limited palette of colors and shapes. But at the basis of all these there was still the constant that the ornament was now useless. The basic idea that the form was a direct expression of the content, not of the external decoration.

4. Ornament in digital world

If we compare the history of modern design with our short history of software and web design, we can see a parallelism. In the same way that in the era of industrialization there was an excessive use of ornament, so **with the advancement of technology in visualization, the result has been a heavy use of decoration for software interfaces and websites.** Designers in the early years of the Web were particularly exploratory on this front, with animation and sound that combined with images went on to produce overly rich and often boisterous experiences.

The first operating systems with graphical interfaces were still quite simple in their look and feel. Using metaphors from the sensible world, we tried to iconically recall commonly used objects, such as the folder icon to represent file directories. But the overall aesthetic was quite flat and linear. Regardless of whether the designer wanted to offer a richer visual experience, the low resolution of the black and white displays limited them.

With the evolution of technology, machines and operating systems that are increasingly powerful and evolved, designers have allowed themselves greater visual freedom with their interfaces. With Windows XP, **Microsoft** introduced a colourful style, giving it a somewhat "physical" look, with lots of highlights, shadows and shades.

Apple has gone even further with the release of Mac OS X, an interface with glossy plastic bubbles, brushed aluminum and realistic icons.

Over time, the visual style of operating systems continued to grow in intensity.

Microsoft has given Windows a shiny clear glass-like theme, while Apple has also introduced more materials and **scheumorphic** cues into its desktop operating system.

op and mobile, such as textures that recalled the skin in his calendar app and the effects of the pages that turn realistically in his book reader.

Styles that mimic real objects and textures are called “**scheuomorphs**” - that is, as we said, design **elements based on symbols borrowed from the real world**, for the sole purpose of making an interface look familiar to the user. Recently, designers have begun to question this styling logic.

An application of notes such as a pad of paper, or the addition of leather and the graphic effects of the pages that turn to a calendar application. These effects can provide an interesting visual experience, but they are also relics of another time, relics that link an interface to "static" real-life objects that are incompatible with the fluidity and dynamism of digital interfaces.

With the latest version of Windows 8, Microsoft has taken a bold step away from this scenario, trying to give its operating system a whole new look, and according to Microsoft an “**authentic**” look. The latest interface is based on principles that Microsoft has developed and applied to the previous version of its mobile operating system, which presents the user with an aesthetic that is almost entirely free of textures or imitations of real-life objects.

Windows 8 relies on typography, spacing and color to bring order and elegance to our digital screen. Real effects and superfluous styles are discarded, and all that's left is simply the content. Just as for Muthesius railway stations were examples of *Maschinenstil*, the designers at Microsoft took as an example “the station” as the source of inspiration for the new graphical interface of Windows, formally called and known as “Metro”.

The Web has seen a similar transformation over the years. The initial HTML table-based layouts and Internet sites built in Flash gave developers virtually total control over interfaces, and so designers didn't hesitate to create visually rich containers for their content. As we have begun to understand in recent years, thanks to the fluidity of CSS, it has been possible to disconnect the aesthetics of the elements (dimensions, colors, layout) of a web page from the content, and thus Web design has become more sober.

Multi-decorated containers with shadow and bevel effects (obtained thanks to images that served as the background of the container) developed in tables could not change their width and position easily. With the

advent of CSS, designers have used fewer images and structured sites to make their layouts more adaptable and easier to maintain.

The latest recent evolution is that of **reactive design**, or **responsive design** (which is the technology that allows you to adapt the single page to the various screen sizes, based on the device with which you view it), as well as the transition between designers web to work directly on the code from the beginning, skipping graphic editors like Photoshop, pushes us even more towards an aesthetic idea of simplicity given by the form, which draws its beauty from typography, spacing and color rather than from a heavy use of textures and decorative images.

Most recently, the chipmunk leader Apple took its first step towards digital authenticity by copying Microsoft with the latest release of its mobile operating system, iOS7. The stitched leather textures have disappeared and the edges of the paper have been torn, replaced by a minimalist interface, mostly flat, with colors, simplified icons and semi-transparent surfaces.

It is clear that in the last period many more professionals are finding more and more steps to connect architecture to the world of information technology and the web.

Before proceeding to a real history of the evolution of **web design** and **web architecture** over the last 20 years, let's think about the most popular sites in the contemporary world.

Let's think of the three most used sites worldwide: Google, born as a search engine, Facebook and Twitter, the two social networks. What do they have in common?

- **Aesthetic success: simplicity and personalization**

Simplicity has always been part of the presentation of these Internet sites: Less is more. Despite the incredible technology behind the structuring of these three sites, the front end, what the user sees has been made as simple and intelligible as possible. This allowed the user a simpler and faster navigation to what he was looking for. Furthermore, do not forget the customization according to your tastes. It is possible to change views, colors. Fill our board with the information and content that we deem most relevant.

- **Social success: interactive activity and interaction**

They are totally interactive places: in addition to being customizable, they allow the personification of the user, who is no longer just a "data", but can actively participate in the social network or the search engine. By inserting any type of information, both textual and multimedia. From the most trivial elements up: your own photograph, a description or your own contents. It also allows interaction with other people, who in turn can be associated with other groups, which generate membership.

- **Information success: the simplicity of reaching information**

The user can quickly access the information he needs. Today, thanks to social networks, search engines and the multitude of Internet sites, the network can be defined as a large world library. Thanks to hypertextuality and multimedia, you can quickly access any type of information and any character. The evolution of social media has also allowed this library to also become social and therefore people too have become information themselves, or rather, they produce information.

5. The history of web design

A journey through the evolution of web design from 2000 to today to try to understand what awaits us in the future.

In the last few years we have seen two big changes on the web. The first big change was definitely the birth of **Facebook**. This new platform, in addition to changing the way people communicate, access different topics of interest and connect people quickly, has attracted many more users. New and old users, of all ages, have begun to become familiar with graphical interfaces, developing an intuition in performing specific actions. Icons and buttons have entered the symbolic landscape of all of us automatically. Even before the birth of Facebook, we started talking about **web 2.0** (of the new millennium) where the user was the protagonist and was at the center of the experience.

So at the beginning of 2000 we have the user at the center of the experience projected towards the interaction with other users. And the websites?

5.1 What happens in the world of the web

Initially the websites were not in step with the news of social media, in fact, the websites of the first part of the 2000s gave a lot of importance to the form, the graphic effects, animations, background music and little consideration for the contents. The websites of these years were very slow, full of heavy images, difficult to navigate.

Dozens of pages for badly organized topics. The concept of graphic layout involved the use of tables and even worse the introduction of websites created in flash.



5.2 The evolution and fall of Flash

The second big change that has affected the world of the web, but also the life of all of us, is certainly the smartphone. The new technologies in telephony, with the possibility of accessing the web, the touch screen and applications have been a great innovation in recent history that has brought even more users to the web and created the need to create new types of graphic interfaces that were easily visible in the different devices.

The famous responsive web design that is still not taken into consideration by everyone today.

Responsive web design means making a web page visible easily when accessed with different devices (smartphone, pc, mac, tablet).

5.3 Apple, Microsoft and Google in the evolution of the history of web design

Smartphones and Social Media have brought the concept of website design a lot forward in a short time. Just a couple of years ago, Apple introduced the concept of “Flat design” into the graphical interfaces of Macs.



5.4 The Modern UI is spelled out by Microsoft as simple, clean and modern

The windows 8 start page is an example of the Modern UI language. The new vision of UI design focuses on fluidity, dynamism, new content concept, interaction, modern typography and, as we will see in Google's material design, on strong and decisive colors. So the definition provided by Microsoft (simple, clean and modern) is a fair slogan when compared to the previous design vision because, what you actually notice is that unlike Apple's clean and minimal design, Microsoft focuses on impact. attractive, intuitive and dynamic.

5.5 The Material Design revolution

On the one hand we have Flat design and on the other the Modern UI language; Google's Material Design intervenes between the two design trends, or rather it merges some of the best features of both styles and evolves them into Material design. A new concept of graphic style with a universal language.

In 2014 Google made a revolution in the graphic design of the web. Material design is a real lifestyle proposed to developers to make their designs more like that of Google. Wanting to educate insiders step by step on the new trend of Material design. The Material design maintains the basic simplicity of Flat design, acquires the bright colors and fluidity of the Modern UI language and adds the concept of giving weight and texture, through the use of shadows, to the different components of the website such as buttons, icons and box.

Creating a design that is perceived as tactile, dividing the parts into different levels of depth, creating a three-dimensional touch. A design increasingly conceived from a smartphone and touch screen perspective. To better understand the Material design just look at the graphics adopted by Google for the different

components such as gmail, google plus and more. To find out, you can consult the "instruction booklet" on Material design.

We now have an idea about the last ten years of web design history, but in conclusion what can we expect for the future of web design?

5.6 From the history of web design to the future

With these assumptions, we will continue to imitate the different graphic layouts proposed by Apple, Microsoft and Google with the difference that Material design could lead to the approval of the websites, as if they were sub-categories of the Google "parent" page. Perhaps it will not be so but the use of the "ways" and "solutions" proposed by Google will push web designers and even more computer developers to consider the advice of "Material design" if only to make the usability. Wanting to go further, perhaps Material design is just Google's first step towards a much larger project.

6. Authentic design

What links the modern movement in architecture to the current change in design in software and the web is the **desire for authenticity**. This drive for greater authenticity is what drives designers to scrape ornaments away from the work that has characterized them for over a hundred years. This force is also the promoter of a digital design that today is moving towards a cleaner form and towards a more functional aesthetic.

7. What makes design more “authentic”?

Authentic design aims to cross the lie and do away with superfluity. Authentic design has to do with the use of materials without the need to mask them in false textures, trying to show off their strengths, instead of trying to hide their weaknesses. Authentic design aims to do away with features that are often included in a product just to make it appear familiar or desirable but that don't actually serve any of these purposes. Authentic design has to do with representing functions in their most optimal form. And with the fact that elegance passes through function.

The authentic design aims to bring down the support erroneously proposed by the external ornaments and encourages you to find beauty within the contents alone. In authentic design, it is not that style is not important, but it is not pursued through decoration. Indeed, the beauty of the form depends on the content, so that the style turns out to be a natural outcome of the creative solution.

Deyan Sudjic commented on the design of the iconic Anglepoise lamp saying: "What the lamp looks like - especially the shape of its shadow - is something that had more to do with an afterthought. But that was part of his charm. The naive line gave it a certain innocence that hinted at authenticity, just like early versions of the Land Rover which had credibility derived more from a basic design of a technically ingenious idea than a willingness to create a seductive consumer product. "

In **digital design**, authenticity can be summarized in three concepts, which can be summarized more or less as follows:

- **Embrace the digital aspect**

There is no need to imitate textures such as metal, wood and leather on the computer screen. They are not the materials with which a digital interface is made, and therefore it is only fake and does not make sense. This doesn't mean that a design should only have backgrounds made of simple colors - rather, it means that we shouldn't try to imitate or be limited by textures from the real world.

- **Do away with the shapelessness**

A digital book does not need to imitate physical paper when turning the page, nor does a note-taking app need to look like a block of paper, with a leather lining, with torn edges and a similar graphic font. Scheuformism is not always bad, but it always introduces unnecessary constraints to the interface. For example, while a block of paper is static and one-dimensional, a digital interface is not, but as long as the interface imitates the paper, it must bear the constraints imposed by the physical metaphor.

- **Content is the center**

Focus on the content, rather than its style and decoration. One might think that this punto is trivial, but how many times have you seen a theme ready on a website? A theme is always built on mannequin content and so, by its very nature, it could never be an optimal representation of the content it will eventually contain. Building themes with fictitious text pushes the designer to focus on design and decoration, rather than content, because there is still no content to work with. Only when you work with the actual content can you begin to truly transform function into form.

8. Modernism 2.0

The design, the beauty of which lies in the function, shares nothing with the minimalist style. When it comes to design and function, we are dealing with a designer who tries to remove the superfluous, to make the product easier to understand, to make it easy to use and to make the most of its contribution. The minimalist style aims to create a minimalist aesthetic, which gives the object an aura of simplicity and cleanliness. The first form of design is a fundamental principle of design, the other a stylistic choice.

It would be a mistake to rigidly apply a minimalist aesthetic design to an interface in the hope of making the interface simpler and digitally “authentic”.

For example, mercilessly eliminating some visual features such as shadows, colors and various background styles will not necessarily result in an easy-to-use interface.

In some cases the opposite would be obtained, undermining the hierarchy and focus, which are instead clearly allowed and facilitated by those same shadows and background colors. In “The Laws of Simplicity” John Maeda poses, *“The simplest way to simplicity is through thoughtful reduction. If in doubt, remove. Just be careful what you remove”*.

This final warning is important. The act of removing often leads to simplicity only because it leads the user to have to deal with fewer elements to process. But removing the visual cues that help the user mentally process the interface - such as graphics that group certain elements or that differentiate buttons and labels and allow certain elements to stand out - could do just the opposite, giving the user more work to do. Thus, instead of designing a design starting from style, one must design it starting from some principles.

The flat style so popular recently can only be a fashion, but also a manifestation of the desire for greater authenticity in design: the desire to curb superfluous decoration in order to focus on content.

Technological progress sometimes leads to excesses, just as the industrial revolution that began in the 19th century led to the abuse of ornaments, display and styling technologies did during the early years of web design and software. But just as ornamental excess has been curbed over time by the pioneers of Modernism, who sought beauty in functionality, today's excesses in software and the web will in the future be held back by an underlying desire for authenticity in design.

We can affirm, without necessarily wanting to support the formation of a modernism 2.0, that the web is going through a very personal aesthetic history extremely close to the architectural one with the succession of eras and styles over time. All incredibly compressed over 20 years or so. It's amazing how somehow *“These forces which often recreate Time and Space, which can shape and alter who we imagine we are, begin long before we are born and continue after we expire.”*

9. Conclusions

Given all this, we can conclude that, to all intents and purposes, Internet has become a tangible place, in which there is a community that can be both active and passive, has a space and its own habitability and consequently its own design. This is fundamental due to the myriad of complex processes that generate it in all spheres, from the most technical to the most aesthetic and finally the most psychological.

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